

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF BRONX-----X
DARREN HAZEL,

Plaintiff,

-against-

CITY OF NEW YORK, ANGEL LOPEZ, ARIANA
ESTEBAN, ANDREW DISTELHURST and JOHN or
JANE DOES I-X,Defendants.
-----X

Index No.

Plaintiff designates
Bronx County as the place of trialThe basis of the venue is where the
injury occurredSUMMONS

TO THE ABOVE-NAMED DEFENDANTS:

YOU ARE HEREBY SUMMONED to answer the complaint in this action and to serve a copy of your answer, or if the complaint is not served with this summons, to serve a notice of appearance, on the Plaintiff's Attorney(s) within 20 days after the service of this summons, exclusive of the day of service (or within 30 days after the service is complete if this summons is not personally delivered to you within the State of New York); and in case of your failure to appear or answer, judgment will be taken against you by default for the relief demanded in the complaint.

Dated: Bayside, New York
November 5, 2019
SIM & DEPAOLA, LLP

By: John K. Kouroupas, Esq.

Attorneys for Plaintiff(s)

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TO: CORPORATION COUNSEL OF THE CITY OF NEW YORK
100 Church Street
New York, New York 10007

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47th NYPD Precinct
4111 Laconia Avenue
Bronx, NY 11466

ARIANA ESTEBAN
47th NYPD Precinct
4111 Laconia Avenue
Bronx, NY 11466

ANDREW DISTELHURST
47th NYPD Precinct
4111 Laconia Avenue
Bronx, NY 11466

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF BRONX

-----X
DARREN HAZEL,

VERIFIED COMPLAINT

Plaintiff,

Index No.

-against-

CITY OF NEW YORK, ANGEL LOPEZ, ARIANA
ESTEBAN, ANDREW DISTELHURST and JOHN or
JANE DOES I-X,

Defendants.

-----X
Plaintiff, Darren Hazel, by and through the undersigned attorneys, Sim & DePaola, LLP,
for his complaint against the Defendants, City of New York, individually and in their official
capacities as New York City police officers, Angel Lopez, Ariana Esteban, and Andrew
Distelhurst and John or Jane Does 1-10, alleges and states as follows:

1. This is a civil rights action, in which plaintiff seeks relief, vis-à-vis 42 U.S.C. §§ 1983, 1985, 1986 and 1988, the common law of the State of New York, in addition to the self-executing clauses or implied private causes of action within the New York State Constitution, for the violations of his civil rights, as guaranteed and protected by the Fourth, Fifth, Sixth and Fourteenth Amendments to the Constitution of the United States, as well as the Laws and Constitution of the State of New York.

2. The Plaintiff, Darren Hazel, asserts that the defendant police officers engaged in a series of four targeted illegal searches and seizures on Plaintiff Darren Hazel between August 9, 2018 and December 31, 2018. In all four incidents, Mr. Hazel was falsely arrested by the same officers or their colleagues, was stopped while driving his vehicle, and taken to a police precinct where he was unlawfully strip searched. As of now, the Civilian Complaint Review Board has

substantiated two of his claims on the grounds that the strip searches were unwarranted and unlawful. As a result, Mr. Hazel was deprived of his liberty and suffered various physical, emotional and psychological injuries. Three of the four false arrests resulted in dismissal of all charges with the one incident pending with an offer of an adjournment in contemplation of dismissal.

3. At all times here mentioned, Defendants were acting under color of state law, to wit, under color of the statutes, ordinances, regulations, policies, customs and usages of the City and State of New York.

4. Within 90 of the claims herein, plaintiff timely serve a notice of claim, upon the City of New York.

5. Over 30 days have elapsed since the filing of this notice, and this matter has not been settled or otherwise disposed of.

6. Plaintiff has complied with municipal defendant's request for an oral examination, pursuant to Section 50-H of the New York General Municipal Law and/or the Public Authorities Law and/or no such request was made within the applicable period.

7. This action and associated claims have been timely commenced within all applicable statutes of limitations.

8. Plaintiff seeks monetary damages (compensatory and punitive) against defendants, an award of costs and reasonable attorneys' fees, and such other and further relief as this Court may deem just and proper.

PARTIES

9. Plaintiff, Darren Hazel ("Mr. Hazel"), presently resides at 666 E. 233rd Street, Apt. 3E, Bronx, New York 10466.

10. Defendant, City of New York (“City”), is a municipal corporation organized under the laws of the State of New York.

11. At all times relevant hereto, defendant City, acting through the New York City Police Department (“NYPD”) or the Bronx County District Attorney’s Office (“BCDA”), was responsible for the policy, practice, supervision, implementation, and conduct of all NYPD matters and was responsible for the appointment, screening, hiring, training, supervision, discipline, retention and conduct of all NYPD personnel, including police officers, detectives, investigators, sergeants, lieutenants and other supervisory officers or officials, as well as the individually named NYPD and Bronx County District Attorney’s Office defendants herein.

12. In addition, at all times here relevant, defendant, City, was responsible for enforcing the rules or regulations of the NYPD and BCDA, and for ensuring that the NYPD and BCDA personnel obey the laws and constitutions of the United States and the State of New York.

13. Defendant, Angel Lopez (“Lopez”), was, at all times here relevant, a police officer employed by the NYPD and, as such, was acting in the capacity of an agent, servant and employee of the defendant, City of New York. Defendant Lopez was, at the times relevant herein, a police officer, under Shield No. 18194, assigned to 47th NYPD Precinct, located at 4111 Laconia Avenue, Bronx, NY 11466. Defendant Lopez is being sued in her individual and official capacities.

14. Defendant, Ariana Esteban (“Esteban”), was, at all times here relevant, a police officer or police detective employed by the NYPD and, as such, was acting in the capacity of an agent, servant and employee of the defendant, City of New York. Defendant Esteban was, at the times relevant herein, a police officer or detective, under Tax Reg. No. 939125, assigned to the 47th

NYPD Precinct, located at 4111 Laconia Avenue, Bronx, NY 11466. Defendant Esteban is being sued in his individual and official capacities.

15. Defendant, Andrew Distelhurst (“Distelhurst”), was, at all times here relevant, a police officer employed by the NYPD and, as such, was acting in the capacity of an agent, servant and employee of the defendant, City of New York. Defendant Distelhurst was, at the times relevant herein, a police officer, under Tax Reg. No. 946466, assigned to the 47th NYPD Precinct, located at 4111 Laconia Avenue, Bronx, NY 11466. Defendant Distelhurst is being sued in his individual and official capacities.

16. At all relevant times, defendants John or Jane Does 1 through 10 were police officers, detectives, supervisors, policymakers or officials employed by the NYPD, BCDA or City of New York. At this time, Plaintiff does not know the true names or tax registry numbers of defendants, John or Jane Does 1 through 10, as such knowledge is within the exclusive possession of defendants.

17. At all relevant times herein, defendants John or Jane Does 1 through 10 were acting as agents, servants and employees of the City of New York, BCDA or the NYPD. Defendants John or Jane Doe 1 through 10 are being sued in their individual and official capacities.

18. At all relevant times herein, defendants were acting under color of state law, to wit, under color of the statutes, ordinances, regulations, policies, customs and usages of the City or State of New York.

FACTUAL CHARGES

19. The Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, engaged in a series of targeted illegal searches and seizures on Plaintiff Darren Hazel between August 9, 2019 and December 31, 2019.

20. On August 9, 2018, at approximately 1:30 AM, in the vicinity of 234th Street, between White Plains Road and Carpenter Avenue, County of Bronx, State of New York, Claimant was driving a vehicle when the vehicle was illegally stopped by defendants, including Lopez and Esteban.

21. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, did not have a legal reason to stop Mr. Hazel as he had not committed any crime or violation of the law, he had not committed any traffic infraction, nor had he exhibited any suspicious activity to cause the defendants to stop the vehicle.

22. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, had absolutely no probable cause to stop, search and detain Mr. Hazel.

23. At no point did defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, ever observe Mr. Mr. Hazel in possession of any controlled substance or other illegal item.

24. At no point did defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, ever possess, recover or observe any evidence reasonably calculated to establish or prove that Mr. Hazel was in possession of any controlled substance or other illegal item.

25. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst committed multiple assault and batteries to Mr. Hazel's person including but not limited to being handcuffed.

26. Mr. Hazel was falsely charged under Summons No. 4446044905 and Summons Docket No. 2018SX018886.

27. Defendant Esteban was the supervising sergeant assigned to Mr. Hazel's arrest, who authorized, approved and/or ordered the arrest and criminal prosecution of Mr. Hazel, despite his full knowledge that Mr. Hazel had committed no crimes or violations of the law.

28. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, forwarded false information to the Bronx County District Attorney's Office, namely that Mr. Hazel was driving a vehicle in an unlawful manner and was unlawfully in possession of a controlled substance or other illegal item, as well as the aforementioned fabricated evidence against Mr. Hazel, despite each defendant being fully aware of Mr. Hazel's complete innocence.

29. Mr. Hazel was held unlawfully over the course of five (5) hours.

30. Mr. Hazel was subjected to an unlawful strip-search inside of the at an NYPD Precinct by, or at the direction of, defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst.

31. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, engaged in a conspiracy to falsely arrest and maliciously prosecute Mr. Hazel by personally conferring with each other, regarding the fabrication of the aforementioned non-existent evidence, as well the manner and means by which said fabrications would be forwarded to the District Attorney's Office.

32. Mr. Hazel was subjected to said unlawful restrictions upon his liberty, until all criminal charges were dismissed on August 31, 2018 in Part SAP-D, which represents a termination to the criminal proceedings in favor of Mr. Hazel.

33. August 17, 2018, at approximately 4:24 AM, in the vicinity of 658 East 232nd Street, County of the Bronx, State of New York, Claimant was driving a vehicle when the vehicle was illegally stopped by defendants, including Lopez and Esteban.

34. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, did not have a legal reason to stop Mr. Hazel as he had not committed any crime or violation of the law, he had not committed any traffic infraction, nor had he exhibited any suspicious activity to cause the defendants to stop the vehicle.

35. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, had absolutely no probable cause to stop, search and detain Mr. Hazel.

36. At no point did defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, ever observe Mr. Hazel in possession of any controlled substance or other illegal item.

37. At no point did defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, ever possess, recover or observe any evidence reasonably calculated to establish or prove that Mr. Hazel was in possession of any controlled substance or other illegal item.

38. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst committed multiple assault and batteries to Mr. Hazel's person including but not limited to being handcuffed.

39. Mr. Hazel was falsely arrested under Summons No. 4444665393 and Summons Docket No. 2018SX020193.

40. Defendant Esteban was the supervising sergeant assigned to Mr. Hazel's arrest, who authorized, approved and/or ordered the arrest and criminal prosecution of Mr. Hazel, despite his full knowledge that Mr. Hazel had committed no crimes or violations of the law.

41. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, forwarded false information to the Bronx County District Attorney's Office, namely that Mr. Hazel was driving a vehicle in an unlawful manner and was unlawfully in possession of a controlled substance or other illegal item, as well as the aforementioned fabricated evidence against Mr. Hazel, despite each defendant being fully aware of Mr. Hazel's complete innocence.

42. Claimant was held unlawfully over the course of four (4) hours.

43. Mr. Hazel was subjected to an unlawful strip-search inside of the at an NYPD Precinct by, or at the direction of, defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst.

44. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, engaged in a conspiracy to falsely arrest and maliciously prosecute Mr. Hazel by personally conferring with each other, regarding the fabrication of the aforementioned non-existent evidence, as well the manner and means by which said fabrications would be forwarded to the District Attorney's Office.

45. Mr. Hazel was subjected to said unlawful restrictions upon his liberty, until all criminal charges were dismissed on September 18, 2018 in Part SAP-D, which represents a termination to the criminal proceedings in favor of Mr. Hazel.

46. On or about October 29, 2018 at approximately 8:30 PM, in the vicinity of 666 East 233rd Street, County of Bronx York, State of New York, Claimant was driving a vehicle when the vehicle was illegally stopped by defendants, including Lopez and Esteban.

47. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, did not have a legal reason to stop Mr. Hazel as he had not committed any crime or violation of the law, he had not committed any traffic infraction, nor had he exhibited any suspicious activity to cause the defendants to stop the vehicle.

48. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, had absolutely no probable cause to stop, search and detain Mr. Hazel.

49. At no point did defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, ever observe Mr. Mr. Hazel in possession of any controlled substance or other illegal item.

50. At no point did defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, ever possess, recover or observe any evidence reasonably calculated to establish or prove that Mr. Hazel was in possession of any controlled substance or other illegal item.

51. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst committed multiple assault and batteries to Mr. Hazel's person including but not limited to being handcuffed.

52. Mr. Hazel was falsely arrested under Summons Docket No. 2018SX026324.

53. Defendant Esteban was the supervising sergeant assigned to Mr. Hazel's arrest, who authorized, approved and/or ordered the arrest and criminal prosecution of Mr. Hazel, despite his full knowledge that Mr. Hazel had committed no crimes or violations of the law.

54. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, forwarded false information to the Bronx County District Attorney's Office, namely that Mr. Hazel was driving a vehicle in an unlawful manner and was unlawfully in possession of a controlled substance or other illegal item, as well as the aforementioned fabricated evidence against Mr. Hazel, despite each defendant being fully aware of Mr. Hazel's complete innocence.

55. Mr. Hazel was held unlawfully over the course of twenty-four (24) hours.

56. Mr. Hazel was subjected to an unlawful strip-search inside of the at an NYPD Precinct by, or at the direction of, defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst.

57. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, engaged in a conspiracy to falsely arrest and maliciously prosecute Mr. Hazel by personally conferring with each other, regarding the fabrication of the aforementioned non-existent evidence, as well the manner and means by which said fabrications would be forwarded to the District Attorney's Office.

58. Mr. Hazel was subjected to said unlawful restrictions upon his liberty, until all criminal charges were dismissed on August 31, 2018 in Part SAP-D, which represents a termination to the criminal proceedings in favor of Mr. Hazel.

59. December 31, 2018, at approximately 1:00 AM, in the vicinity of Furman Avenue and White Plains Road, County of the Bronx, State of New York, Claimant was driving a vehicle when the vehicle was illegally stopped by defendants, including Lopez and Esteban.

60. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, did not have a legal reason to stop Mr. Hazel as he had not committed any crime or violation of the law, he had not committed any traffic infraction, nor had he exhibited any suspicious activity to cause the defendants to stop the vehicle.

61. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, had absolutely no probable cause to stop, search and detain Mr. Hazel.

62. At no point did defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, ever observe Mr. Mr. Hazel in possession of any controlled substance or other illegal item.

63. At no point did defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, ever possess, recover or observe any evidence reasonably calculated to establish or prove that Mr. Hazel was in possession of any controlled substance or other illegal item.

64. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst committed multiple assault and batteries to Mr. Hazel's person including but not limited to being handcuffed.

65. Mr. Hazel was falsely arrested under Criminal Docket No. 2018BX042371.

66. Defendant Esteban was the supervising sergeant assigned to Mr. Hazel's arrest, who authorized, approved and/or ordered the arrest and criminal prosecution of Mr. Hazel, despite his full knowledge that Mr. Hazel had committed no crimes or violations of the law.

67. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, forwarded false information to the Bronx County District Attorney's Office, namely that Mr. Hazel was driving a vehicle in an unlawful manner and was unlawfully in possession of a controlled substance or other illegal item, as well as the aforementioned fabricated evidence against Mr. Hazel, despite each defendant being fully aware of Mr. Hazel's complete innocence.

68. Mr. Hazel was held unlawfully over the course of twenty (20) hours.

69. Mr. Hazel was subjected to an unlawful strip-search inside of the at an NYPD Precinct by, or at the direction of, defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst.

70. Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, engaged in a conspiracy to falsely arrest and maliciously prosecute Mr. Hazel by personally conferring with each other, regarding the fabrication of the aforementioned non-existent evidence, as well the manner and means by which said fabrications would be forwarded to the District Attorney's Office.

71. Mr. Hazel was subjected to said unlawful restrictions upon his liberty, while said criminal charges are pending.

72. Plaintiff asserts that the defendants, including Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, who violated plaintiff's civil rights, are part of a larger pattern and practice of similar misconduct, which is so widespread, pervasive and consistent throughout the NYPD and the City of New York that the commission such constitutionally violative behavior has become tantamount to an official policy or custom within the NYPD and City of New York or, at the very least, conclusive evidence that the City and the NYPD have either tacitly approved of such egregious wrongdoings or that they have become deliberately indifferent to the civil rights of those who may come into contact with their police officers.

73. The individually named defendants herein, as well as other officers serving in the employ of the NYPD and City of New York, have blatantly, shamelessly, consistently and repeatedly engaged in conduct violative of the civil rights guaranteed and protected by Constitution of the United States, in addition to the laws and Constitution of the State of New York, all without incurring any ramifications for such misconduct and, ostensibly, with the full and complete blessing of the NYPD, the City of New York and their respective policymakers and supervisors.

74. *The New York Times*, as well as numerous other reputable journalistic enterprises, have reported on the widespread corruption within the NYPD and City of New York, particularly the incredibly disconcerting proclivity of many NYPD officers to lie about subject matters that are materially relevant to criminal prosecutions, including the complete fabrication of arrest evidence and witnesses. Also detailed, is the NYPD's obstinate refusal to effectuate corrective or preventive measures to combat the inevitable recurrence of such misdeeds, and perhaps most troubling, the NYPD's alarming tendency to, instead, reward and promote these officers, including those who were inculcated via some incontrovertible form of evidence.

75. On March 18, 2018, *The New York Times* published an explosive article, entitled "Promotions, Not Punishments for Officers Accused of Lying," written by Joseph Goldstein. Mr. Goldstein shines a light on the multitude of flaws within the CCRB and the NYPD, highlighting the fact that the substantiation of a claim against an officer will invariably rely on the presence of incontrovertible proof against the officer. Due to the rarity availability of this type of evidence, an alarmingly small percentage of officer misconduct claims are substantiated. The CCRB is further handicapped by a terribly designed system that requires evidence of a virtually indisputable nature to substantiate any claim against an officer. The article also details the NYPD's persistent reluctance to investigate or discipline officers who lie and even posits that this reluctance is a significant cause of the lying pandemic within the NYPD. The article references various officers and detectives who were the subject of credible accusations relating to the officers' intentionally false statements, with some allegations coming from federal and state judges.

76. On September 12, 2019, *The New York Times* published another article by Joseph Goldstein, entitled "Officers Said They Smelled Pot. The Judge Called Them Liars."

Unsurprisingly, this article dealt with the unusually high frequency of officers using the odor of marijuana to excuse a search that conspicuously does not result in the recovery of any marijuana. It should not require an article in *The New York Times* to call attention to such patently disingenuous tactics, but has become necessary for a variety of reasons, including the NYPD's failure to correct such behavior, the willingness of prosecutors and judges to credit the lying officers and the increasing rate of occurrence.

77. On April 24, 2019, *The New York Times* published an article, entitled "Detective's Lies Sent Three People to Prison, Prosecutors Charge," by Sean Piccolo, detailing the lies of NYPD Second Grade Detective Joseph Franco and how those lies resulted in the imprisonment of at least three innocent people. The article described how Det. Franco lied about observing drug transactions on at least three separate occasions, lies that were only uncovered through contradictory video evidence. Det. Franco's lies resulted in the innocent individuals each being sentenced to prison terms in excess of one-year.

78. Other articles include: (i) "Testilying' by Police: A Stubborn Problem.," by Joseph Goldstein, *The New York Times*, March 18, 2018; (ii) "New York Detective Charged with Faking Lineup Results," by Joseph Goldstein, *The New York Times*, February 17, 2018; (iii) "He Excelled as a Detective, Until Prosecutors Stopped Believing Him," by Joseph Goldstein, *The New York Times*, October 17, 2017; (iv) "Review Board Notes Rise in New York Police Officers' False Statement," by J. David Goodman, *The New York Times*, May 14, 2015; (v) "In Brooklyn Gun Cases, Suspicion Turns to the Police," by Stephanie Clifford, *The New York Times*, December 11, 2014; (vi) "Detective is Found Guilty of Planting Drugs," by Tim Stelloh, *The New York Times*, November 1, 2011; and (vii) "The Drugs? They Came From the Police," by Jim Dwyer, *The New York Times*, October 13, 2011.

79. The NYPD has a longstanding and ignominious record of failing to discipline its officers, or even entertaining allegations of wrongdoing against them. On June 26, 2019, *The New York Times* published an article, entitled “2,495 Reports of Police Bias. Not One Was Deemed Valid by the N.Y.P.D.” This article reported that within the last five (5) years, almost 2,500 separate individuals have filed formal complaints with the NYPD alleging that an officer acted with bias toward them, with not a single one being substantiated by the NYPD. Such a finding is plainly incredible and obviously the result of deliberately poor or nonexistent investigatory protocols. The report further impugned the NYPD’s commitment to combat the prejudices and the biases exhibited by many of its officers.

80. Upon information and belief, the NYPD, the City of New York, and their respective policymakers, officials or supervisors have imposed, tacitly approved or acquiesced to policies, customs, or patterns and practices within the NYPD that resulted in plaintiff’s arrest without probable cause.

81. Upon information and belief, the NYPD, the City of New York, and their respective policymakers or supervisors have failed to provide adequate training regarding the identification of probable cause, reasonable suspicion or the appropriate amount of force to be used.

82. Defendants’ actions, pursuant to plaintiff’s underlying arrest, which occurred without even the semblance of probable cause, were so blatantly violative of plaintiff’s civil rights that the tacit approval of identical or similar acts by the policymakers or supervisors of the NYPD and the City of New York, as well as their deliberate indifference towards the rights of any individuals who may come into contact with defendants, should be inferred, because such flagrant deprivations of constitutionally protected rights could not and would not occur without

the tacit approval or deliberate indifference regarding the commission of such violations by the policymakers or supervisors of the NYPD and City of New York.

83. Upon information and belief, further details and facts, relating to the unlawful policies, customs or patterns and practices of the NYPD, City of New York and their respective policymakers, supervisors, police officers or employees, will become known after the completion of discovery, as such information is presently within the exclusive possession of defendants, the NYPD and City of New York.

84. Upon information and belief, the personnel files, records and disciplinary histories of the officer defendants will reveal a history of Constitutional violations indicative of defendant City's knowledge that the individual officer defendants were unfit for employment as NYPD officers, or for employment in general, and that the probability of the individually named defendants committing similar violations in the future was extremely high.

85. Upon information and belief, said personnel files, records and disciplinary histories will conclusively show that the City and the NYPD were fully aware of defendants' past constitutional violations, the unacceptably high probability for the recurrence of similar transgressions, the unreasonably dangerous situations that were likely to result from their hiring or retention, as well as their unsuitability for employment as law enforcement officers, or for employment in general, and that the NYPD and City of New York failed to engage in any preventive or corrective action intended to diminish the likelihood of recurrence for such violations, which is tantamount to the City's tacit approval of such misconduct or the City's deliberate indifference towards the civil rights of those who may interact with its employees, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst.

86. Upon information and belief, the individually named defendants have combined to be named as defendants in numerous lawsuits that have accused them of committing violations similar or identical to those alleged herein.

87. Upon information and belief, the NYPD and City of New York and have failed, or outright refused, to correct the individually named defendants' predilections to engage in unconstitutional behavior or attempt to prevent the recurrence of such misconduct

88. The aforementioned acts of defendants, including the City, Defendants, including Lopez, Esteban, and Distelhurst, directly or proximately resulted in the deprivation or violation of Mr. Hazel' civil rights, as guaranteed and protected by the Fourth, Fifth, Sixth and Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution, as well as the laws and Constitution of the State of New York.

89. As a direct or proximate result of said acts, Mr. Hazel was caused to suffer the loss of his liberty, irreparable reputational harm, loss of earnings and potential earnings, physical injury, as well as severe and permanent emotional distress, including fear, embarrassment, humiliation, traumatization, frustration, extreme inconvenience, and anxiety.

FIRST CAUSE OF ACTION

Unlawful Search and Seizure Under
New York State Law

90. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

91. Defendants subjected plaintiff and his property to unreasonable searches and seizures without a valid warrant and without reasonable suspicion or probable cause do so.

92. Plaintiff was conscious and fully aware of the unreasonable searches and seizures to his person and property.

93. Plaintiff did not consent to the unreasonable searches and seizures to his person or property.

94. The unreasonable searches and seizures to plaintiff's person and property were not otherwise privileged.

95. Accordingly, defendants violated plaintiff's right to be free from unreasonable searches and seizures, pursuant to the Fourth Amendment to the United States Constitution and Article I, Section 12, of the New York State Constitution.

96. Defendant City of New York, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoings under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

97. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

SECOND CAUSE OF ACTION

Unlawful Search and Seizure Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Individual Defendants

98. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

99. Defendants subjected plaintiff and his property to unreasonable searches and seizures without a valid warrant and without reasonable suspicion or probable cause do so.

100. Plaintiff was conscious and fully aware of the unreasonable searches and seizures to his person and property.

101. Plaintiff did not consent to the unreasonable searches and seizures to his person or property.

102. The unreasonable searches and seizures to plaintiff's person and property were not otherwise privileged.

103. Accordingly, defendants violated plaintiff's right to be free from unreasonable searches and seizures, pursuant to the Fourth Amendment to the United States Constitution and Article I, Section 12, of the New York State Constitution.

104. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

THIRD CAUSE OF ACTION

False Arrest and False Imprisonment Under New York State Law

105. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

106. Defendants subjected Plaintiff to false arrest, false imprisonment, and deprivation of liberty without a valid warrant or probable cause.

107. Plaintiff was conscious of his confinement.

108. Plaintiff did not consent to his confinement.

109. Plaintiff's arrest and false imprisonment was not otherwise privileged.

110. Defendant City of New York, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoings under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

111. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

FOURTH CAUSE OF ACTION

False Arrest and False Imprisonment Under 42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Individual Defendants

112. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

113. The Defendants violated the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments to the U.S. Constitution by wrongfully and illegally arresting, detaining and imprisoning Plaintiff.

114. The wrongful, unjustifiable, and unlawful apprehension, arrest, detention, and imprisonment of Plaintiff was carried out without a valid warrant, without Plaintiff's consent, and without probable cause or reasonable suspicion.

115. At all relevant times, Defendants acted forcibly in apprehending, arresting, and imprisoning Plaintiff.

116. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

FIFTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Assault and Battery Under
New York State Law

117. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

118. At all relevant times, Defendants caused Plaintiff to fear for his physical well-being and safety and placed him in apprehension of immediate harmful and/or offensive touching.

119. Defendants engaged in and subjected Plaintiff to immediate harmful and/or offensive touching and battered him without his consent or justification.

120. Due to the intentional, willful and unlawful acts of Defendants, Plaintiff suffered damages.

121. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

122. As a direct and proximate result of this breach, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

SIXTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Excessive Force Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Individual Defendants

123. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

124. The Defendants violated Plaintiff's rights under the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments, because they used unreasonable force without Plaintiff's consent.

125. Defendants engaged in and subjected Plaintiff to immediate harmful and/or offensive touching and battered him without his consent.

126. As a direct and proximate result of this breach, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

SEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Malicious Prosecution Under
New York State Law

127. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

128. Defendants initiated the prosecution against Plaintiff.

129. Defendants lacked probable cause to believe Plaintiff was guilty or that the prosecution would succeed.

130. Defendants acted with malice, which, in the absence of probable cause, may be inferred.

131. The prosecution was terminated in Plaintiff's favor, when all criminal charges were unconditionally dismissed and sealed.

132. Due to the intentional, willful and unlawful acts of Defendants, Plaintiff suffered significant damages.

133. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

134. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

EIGHTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Malicious Prosecution Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Individual Defendants

135. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

136. Defendants initiated the prosecution against Plaintiff.
137. Defendants lacked probable cause to believe Plaintiff was guilty or that the prosecution would succeed.
138. Defendants acted with malice, which, in the absence of probable cause, may be inferred.
139. The prosecution was terminated in Plaintiff's favor, when all criminal charges were unconditionally dismissed and sealed.
140. Defendants violated Plaintiff's Fourth and Fourteenth Amendment rights by causing Plaintiff to remain unlawfully incarcerated after his arraignment and trial by jury
141. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

NINTH CAUSE OF ACTION
Malicious Abuse of Process Under
New York State Law

142. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.
143. Defendants arrested, detained and caused a criminal prosecution to be initiated against Plaintiff to compel the compliance or forbearance of some act.
144. Defendants had no excuse or justification to forcibly detain or initiate a prosecution against Plaintiff, especially with the absence of any cognizable probable cause.
145. Defendants intended to inflict substantial harm upon Plaintiff.
146. Defendants acted to achieve a collateral purpose, beyond or in addition to Plaintiff's criminal prosecution.
147. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.
148. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

TENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Malicious Abuse of Process Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Individual Defendants

149. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.
150. Defendants arrested, detained and caused a criminal prosecution to be initiated against Plaintiff to compel the compliance or forbearance of some act.
151. Defendants had no excuse or justification to forcibly detain and initiate a prosecution against Plaintiff, especially with the absence of any cognizable probable cause.
152. Defendants intended to inflict substantial harm upon Plaintiff.
153. Defendants acted to achieve a collateral purpose, beyond or in addition to Plaintiff's criminal prosecution.
154. Defendants' actions deprived Plaintiff of his constitutional rights to free from illegal searches and seizures and to not be deprived of his liberty without the due process of law.
155. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

ELEVENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Denial of Right to Fair Trial Under
New York State Law

156. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.
157. Defendants fabricated false evidence to be used against Plaintiff that was likely to influence a jury's decision and forwarded said false information to the New York County District Attorney's Office.
158. Defendants' actions deprived Plaintiff of his right to a fair trial and caused post-arraignment restrictions to be imposed on his liberty and freedom of movement.

159. Accordingly, defendants violated Plaintiff's right to fair trial, pursuant to the Sixth and Fourteenth Amendments to United States Constitution, Article I, Sections 1, 2 and 6 of the New York State Constitution, as well Article II, Section 12, of the New York State Civil Rights Law.

160. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

161. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

TWELFTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Denial of Right to Fair Trial Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Individual Defendants

162. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

163. Defendants fabricated false evidence to be used against Plaintiff that was likely to influence a jury's decision and forwarded said false information to the New York County District Attorney's Office.

164. Defendants' actions deprived Plaintiff of his right to a fair trial and caused post-arraignment restrictions to be imposed on his liberty and freedom of movement.

165. Accordingly, defendants violated Plaintiff's right to fair trial, pursuant to the Sixth and Fourteenth Amendments to United States Constitution, Article I, Sections 1, 2 and 6 of the New York State Constitution, as well Article II, Section 12, of the New York State Civil Rights Law.

166. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

THIRTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Conspiracy to Interfere with Civil Rights and Failure to Prevent the Conspiracy under
42 U.S.C. §§ 1983, 1985 and 1986 Against Individual Defendants

167. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

168. Defendants engaged in a conspiracy against Plaintiff to deprive Plaintiff of his rights to engage in protected speech or activities, to be free from unreasonable searches and seizures, to be afforded a fair trial, to not be deprived of his liberty or property without due process of law, or of the privileges and immunities under the laws and constitutions of the United States and of the State of New York.

169. Defendants committed overt acts in furtherance of their conspiracy against Plaintiff.

170. As a result, Plaintiff sustained injuries to his person, was deprived of his liberty or was deprived of rights or privileges of citizens of the United States.

171. Defendants' conspiracy was motivated by a desire to deprive Plaintiff of his civil rights or because of some racial, otherwise class-based, invidious or discriminatory animus.

172. The Defendants that did not engage or participate in the conspiracy to interfere with Plaintiff's civil rights, had knowledge that acts in furtherance of the conspiracy were about to be committed or in process of being committed, possessed the power to prevent or aid in the prevention of the conspiratorial objective, and neglected to do so.

173. Accordingly, defendants violated Plaintiff's rights, pursuant to the Fourth, Fifth, Sixth and/or Fourteenth Amendments to the United States Constitution.

174. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

FOURTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Failure to Intervene Under
New York State Law

175. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

176. Those Defendants that were present but did not actively participate in the aforementioned unlawful conduct, observed such conduct, had an opportunity to prevent such conduct, had a duty to intervene and prevent such conduct, and failed to intervene.

177. Defendant City, as employer of the individual Defendants, is responsible for their wrongdoing under the doctrine of *respondeat superior*.

178. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

FIFTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Failure to Intervene Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Individual Defendants

179. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth herein.

180. Those Defendants that were present but did not actively participate in the aforementioned unlawful conduct observed such conduct, had an opportunity to prevent such conduct, had a duty to intervene and prevent such conduct, and failed to intervene.

181. Accordingly, the Defendants who failed to intervene violated the Fourth and Fourteenth Amendments.

182. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

SIXTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Negligent Hiring, Training, Retention and Supervision Under
New York State Law

183. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

184. Defendant City owed a duty of care to Plaintiff to adequately hire, train, retain and supervise its employee defendants.

185. Defendant City breached those duties of care.

186. Defendant City placed defendants in a position where they could inflict foreseeable harm.

187. Defendant City knew or should have known of its employee defendants' propensity for violating the individual rights granted under the United States Constitution and the laws of the State of New York, prior to the injuries incurred by Plaintiff.

188. Defendant City failed to take reasonable measures in hiring, training, retaining and supervising its employee defendants that would have prevented the aforesaid injuries to Plaintiff.

189. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, Plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

SEVENTEENTH CAUSE OF ACTION

Municipal "*Monell*" Liability Under
42 U.S.C. § 1983 Against Defendant City

190. The above paragraphs are here incorporated by reference as though fully set forth.

191. Defendant City maintained a policy or custom that caused Plaintiff to be deprived of his civil rights, tacitly approved of such violative conduct or was deliberately indifferent toward the potential exposure of individuals, such as plaintiff, to such violative behavior.

192. Defendant City's employee police officers have engaged in an illegal pattern and practice of misconduct, so consistent and widespread that it constitutes a custom or usage, of which a supervisor or policymaker must have been aware of.

193. Defendant City, its policymakers and supervisors failed to provide adequate training or supervision to their subordinates, to such an extent that is tantamount to the City's deliberate indifference toward the rights of those who may come into contact with defendant City's employees.

194. Defendant City's employees engaged in such egregious and flagrant violations of plaintiff's Constitutional rights that the need for enhanced training or supervision is obvious and

equates to a display of deliberate indifference by defendant City and its policymakers toward the rights of individuals, who may come into contact with defendant City's employees.

195. Defendant City's repeated refusal or failure to install or apply corrective or preventive measures constitutes the tacit approval of such violative behavior or a deliberate indifference to the rights of those who may be affected by such behavior.

196. Defendant City's conduct caused the violation of plaintiff's civil rights enumerated within the Constitution of the United States.

197. As a direct and proximate result of this unlawful conduct, plaintiff sustained the damages hereinbefore alleged.

WHEREFORE, Plaintiff respectfully requests judgment against Defendants, jointly and severally, as follows:

- a) On the First Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- b) On the Second Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- c) On the Third Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;

- d) On the Fourth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- e) On the Fifth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- f) On the Sixth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- g) On the Seventh Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- h) On the Eighth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- i) On the Ninth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- j) On the Tenth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;

- k) On the Eleventh Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- l) On the Twelfth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- m) On the Thirteenth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- n) On the Fourteenth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- o) On the Fifteenth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- p) On the Sixteenth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- q) On the Seventeenth Cause of Action, in a sum of money having a present value which exceeds the jurisdictional limits of all lower courts which would otherwise have jurisdiction of this matter;
- r) Awarding Plaintiff punitive damages in an amount to be determined by a jury on all causes of action set forth herein;

s) Awarding Plaintiff reasonable attorneys' fees and costs pursuant to 42 U.S.C. § 1988;

Together with the costs and disbursements of this action.

JURY DEMAND

Plaintiff demands a trial by jury.

Dated: November 5, 2019

Respectfully submitted,



SIM & DEPAOLA, LLP

By: John K. Kouroupas, Esq.

Attorneys for Mr. Hazel

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ATTORNEY VERIFICATION

I, John K. Kouroupas, an attorney admitted to practice in the courts of New York State, state that I am an associate with the firm of **SIM & DEPAOLA, LLP**, the attorneys of record for Plaintiffs in the within action; I have read the foregoing and know the contents thereof; the same is true to my own knowledge, except as to the matters therein stated to be alleged on information and belief, and as to those matters I believe it to be true. The reason this verification is made by me and not by Plaintiffs, is because Plaintiffs reside outside the county where deponent maintains his office. I affirm that the foregoing statements are true, under the penalties of perjury.

Dated: Bayside, New York
November 5, 2019



JOHN K. KOUROUPAS, ESQ.

Index No.:

SUPREME COURT OF THE STATE OF NEW YORK
COUNTY OF BRONX

DARREN HAZEL,

Plaintiff,

-against-

CITY OF NEW YORK, ANGEL LOPEZ, ARIANA ESTEBAN, ANDREW DISTELHURST
and JOHN or JANE DOES I-X,

Defendants.

SUMMONS AND VERIFIED COMPLAINT

SIM & DEPAOLA, LLP
By: John K. Kouroupas, Esq.
Attorneys for Plaintiff(s)
42-40 Bell Boulevard
Suite 201
Bayside, New York 11361
Tel. (718) 281-0400

To: CORPORATION COUNSEL OF THE CITY OF NEW YORK

Attorney(s) for Defendants

Service of a copy of the within is hereby admitted.

Dated:

Attorney(s) for